

# M2 Lab

## Brand book and design system

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VERSION 2, 8 SEPTEMBER 2026

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PART 1

# Brand book

What M2 Lab is, who it speaks to, how it sounds, and what it will not say.



# Purpose and positioning

## PURPOSE

M2 Lab exists because non-technical business leaders are told that AI changes everything and are never shown what to do on Monday morning. We take one real repeated work process, build a controlled AI workflow around it, test it, and publish the honest verdict. Michael builds the case, Max builds the thing.

## INTERNAL OPERATING STATEMENT, NOT PUBLISHED

We help the person responsible for AI adoption in a small business choose one repeated workflow, break it into fragments, and build the first human-controlled version of it. It decides what we make.

## PUBLIC POSITIONING STATEMENT

**M2 Lab helps non-technical small-business leaders turn AI confusion into clear, useful everyday work, one workflow at a time, without coding or chasing every new tool.**

## SUPPORTING LINE

**Understand what matters. Start with one repeated workflow. Keep a human in control.**

## NOTE ON THE WORDING

The positioning statement is the approved wording and is used whole or not at all. The long dash of the source line is set here as a comma, per the punctuation rule of this book.

## THE M2 METHOD

01

**Repeated  
workflow**

02

**Fragmentation**

03

**AI boundary**

04

**Human review**

05

**First test**

Every piece of content, every offer and every future product reinforces this chain.

# What M2 Lab is, and what it is not

Positioning is decided as much by what we refuse as by what we make. The left column is what the account is allowed to become. The right column is the drift it is checked against, before a topic is scripted and again before it is published.

## ■ WHAT M2 LAB IS

- A practical AI adoption media brand.
- A translator between AI capability and a real repeated work process.
- A builder in public, showing tests, trade-offs, failures and human-review boundaries.
- A future education, diagnostic and scoped implementation business.

## □ WHAT M2 LAB IS NOT

- A generic AI news account.
- A tool-list or prompt-hack account.
- A "make money with AI" account.
- A sales, marketing, finance, legal or HR expert brand.
- A promise to automate every business process.
- An "AI employee" vendor selling autonomous systems without process ownership and human approval.

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State is read from the shape of the marker, never from its colour: a filled square for what we are, an open square for what we are not.

# Credibility boundary

■ WE CAN CREDIBLY CLAIM TO

- explain AI to non-technical people at a beginner-to-intermediate level;
- break a repeated process into steps, inputs, outputs, decisions and risks;
- assess where AI can assist and where a human stays responsible;
- research tools and market signals;
- build and test a scoped workflow;
- document what worked, what failed and what should not be automated.

■ WE STAY SILENT ON, AND NEVER CLAIM

- guaranteed revenue, conversion, retention, cost savings or productivity gains;
- advice in a business function where we have no evidence or expertise;
- a reliable solution for every reviewed tool or workflow;
- a replacement for professional legal, tax, medical, HR, credit or security judgment;
- AI that makes external decisions or takes actions without human approval.

EXPERIMENT, NOT CASE STUDY

Internal builds are experiments, not client case studies. Say "we tested", "we built", "this broke". Say "client result" only after a real client pilot with an agreed baseline and metric.

LANGUAGE

Public content, website, offers, workshops and cohorts are English only. Keep one language per account.

GEOGRAPHY

Name no country in the public positioning during the first 60 days. The content audience is non-technical, English-working small-business leaders. The initial commercial focus is English-working SMEs in Europe. Netherlands and Ireland are research and outreach hypotheses, not brand identities. Say "for Dutch SMEs" or "for European businesses" only after real local conversations, pilots, or a repeated country-specific problem.

# Audience

THE CORE AUDIENCE, AS A JOB TO BE DONE

The person responsible for figuring out where AI should actually fit in a small business.

This is one job to be done, not one job title. It may be an owner or CEO in a small company, an operations lead, a team lead who owns a recurring process, or a functional manager asked to "figure out AI" for the team. Write to that job, never to a title, and never to a crowd.

THE THREE ROLES IN AN ENGAGEMENT

| ROLE     | WHO THEY ARE                       | WHAT THEY NEED                                                |
|----------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Buyer    | Owner or CEO                       | Clarity, lower chaos, and a team that can use AI responsibly. |
| Champion | Operations or team lead            | A clear first process and a realistic implementation path.    |
| User     | The person doing the repeated task | A workflow that makes work easier and keeps their judgment.   |

AUDIENCE LEVEL, 0 TO 6 OUT OF 10

- They know the main AI tools and may have tried ChatGPT or Claude.
- They have no repeatable way of using them at work.
- They are open to practical no-code or low-code workflows.
- They need plain language and real examples.

Assume they know what a chatbot is. Assume they do not know what an API, a webhook, an embedding or an agent framework is. Define any term the moment it appears.

WHO WE DO NOT SERVE

Advanced technical builders who want local models, deep orchestration, custom infrastructure or multi-agent architecture. When a topic only interests that group, it belongs in the workshop channel or nowhere.

HOW ONE REEL TRAVELS

A Reel usually speaks to the Champion, gets forwarded to the Buyer, and has to survive being read by the User. Write so all three can follow it.

# What they know, and what they came for

THEY KNOW

AI matters, competitors are experimenting, their team is already pasting work into chatbots without a rule, and their days are full of repeated tasks.

THEY DO NOT KNOW

Which task to start with, which tools are worth attention, what output can be trusted, how to introduce AI without creating more chaos, and what a first working version actually looks like.

THEY FEAR

Wasting money on a tool nobody uses, an AI mistake reaching a customer, their data leaking, looking foolish in front of the team, and being sold a transformation they cannot maintain.

## Speak to the fear by naming the human review step, every time.

THE FOUR QUESTIONS THEY BRING

QUESTION

ANSWERED BY

"Is this solution relevant to me?"

M2 Radar

"What does a first working version look like?"

M2 Builds

"Is this process suitable for AI, and how would it work?"

M2 Teardowns

"So what do I do next?"

The closing line of every publication

THE FOURTH QUESTION IS NOT OPTIONAL

If a piece does not answer it, it is not finished. The first three questions decide which of the three formats a topic belongs to. The fourth is answered in every publication, whichever format it is.

# Personality: four traits

Every publication should be recognizable as ours by these traits, with the handle hidden.

| TRAIT                | WHAT IT MEANS                                                                      | WE ARE                                      | WE ARE NOT                                  |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| 1. Evidence-first    | We say a thing only after we have run it, measured it, or read the primary source. | The ones who show the test.                 | The ones who report the news.               |
| 2. Translator        | We convert AI capability into a step of somebody's actual working day.             | Speaking the language of the process owner. | Speaking the language of the release notes. |
| 3. Builder in public | We publish the working version, the trade-off and the part that failed.            | A lab with an open notebook.                | A studio with a showreel.                   |
| 4. Human in control  | Every workflow we publish names who reviews the output and who owns the process.   | Building assistance with an approval step.  | Building autonomy.                          |

EVIDENCE-FIRST, IN CONTENT

A Radar episode about a new model opens with the one task we pointed it at, and the sentence "here is what changed and here is what did not".

TRANSLATOR, IN CONTENT

Instead of naming a context window, we say how many support tickets fit in one pass and what still has to be split by hand.

BUILDER IN PUBLIC, IN CONTENT

A Builds episode names the step where the agent broke and shows the screen where it broke, before the verdict.

HUMAN IN CONTROL, IN CONTENT

Every Teardown ends with a step marked as human-owned and a sentence explaining why that step stays human.

# Voice: principles 1 to 3

The voice is a lab notebook read aloud by a person who respects your time. Precise, evidence-first, specific. The "do not" lines below are the phrasing this niche defaults to; they appear here as examples only and are never published. All numbers on these pages are placeholders that show the pattern. Never publish a number we have not measured.

## PRINCIPLE 1

### Name the process, then the tool

Open with the work, not the technology. The reader recognizes the process before they care about the model.

#### ■ DO

"This model changes one step of quote preparation. Here is which step."

#### ■ DO NOT

"Claude just dropped a new model and it is insane."

## PRINCIPLE 2

### State the number with its baseline

A number only means something next to what it replaced. Always give the before, the after, and the unit.

#### ■ DO

"Sorting 40 inbox requests took 95 minutes. With the workflow it took 22. Saved: 73 minutes a week."

#### ■ DO NOT

"This saved us 80% of the time."

## PRINCIPLE 3

### Publish the failure in the same piece as the result

The break is the proof that the test was real. It goes in the body, not in a reply.

#### ■ DO

"It handled 87 of 100 leads. It broke on companies with no website and invented an industry for them. We added a human check for that case."

#### ■ DO NOT

"This workflow is a total game-changer for lead research."

## Voice: principles 4 to 6

The "do not" lines are the phrasing this niche defaults to; they appear here as examples only and are never published. All numbers on these pages are placeholders that show the pattern.

### PRINCIPLE 4

#### **Responsibility is not a burden**

The named reviewer is the owner's advantage, not a chore. Write the approval step as the place where their judgment stays in the work and their name stays on the output. It is the reason a workflow is trusted and adopted.

##### ■ DO

"The AI drafts the reply and marks its confidence. Anna approves before anything sends, which is why the team runs this on live customer mail."

##### ■ DO NOT

"The AI handles everything for you."

### PRINCIPLE 5

#### **End with one action the viewer can take alone**

Close with the next step in their own work, not a request for engagement.

##### ■ DO

"Take the one workflow you ran three times last week and write down its inputs. That is the whole first step."

##### ■ DO NOT

"Comment WORKFLOW below and I will send it to you."

### PRINCIPLE 6

#### **Let the two of us disagree out loud**

Two names on the account means two readings of the same evidence. Keep the disagreement in the edit.

##### ■ DO

"Michael says this is worth a pilot. Max says the error rate makes it a TEST, not a KEEP. We published both and the number that separates them."

##### ■ DO NOT

"We are the AI workflow experts helping you master automation."

# Tone by context

The voice does not change. The tone flexes with the surface, and each surface has a length it is written to.

Living section. Updated 8 September 2026 from the 1 September radar analysis. Revised after every 12 publications and after each radar run.

| CONTEXT                    | TO NE                                                                                                             | LENGTH                   |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| Reel hook, 0 to 3 s        | Flat, concrete, one claim about a process. No question, no tease.                                                 | 6-8 words on screen      |
| Reel body and voice-over   | Spoken, plain, one idea per sentence. Terms defined the moment they appear.                                       | 12-18 words per sentence |
| Caption                    | Written, denser than the voice-over. Search words in the first line. Adds what the Reel could not fit.            | 60-120 words             |
| Carousel slide             | Notebook shorthand. One statement, one artifact, no paragraphs.                                                   | Under 20 words           |
| Bio                        | Topic first, roles second. No teaching register, no promise.                                                      | Under 150 characters     |
| Replies to comments        | Warm, specific, answer the actual question. Ask what the process is before advising.                              | 1-3 sentences            |
| Replies to criticism       | Thank, concede what is correct, give the number or say we do not have it. Never defend a claim we cannot support. | 1-3 sentences            |
| Sponsored Radar disclosure | Plain and first, before the content: who paid, what we tested anyway, that the verdict is ours.                   | 1-2 sentences            |

# Sentence patterns

## HOW WE STATE A VERDICT

### Label, then reason, then condition.

"M2 VERDICT: TEST. Why: it handles clean inputs and fails on scanned documents. Revisit when your inputs are digital."

Use KEEP when it stays in our own workflow. Use TEST when it works under a named condition. Use KILL when we removed it and can say what broke.

## HOW WE END

### One instruction they do today.

"Open your last week and find the workflow you ran three times. Write down what goes in and what comes out. Start there."

Acceptable alternatives: "Save this before your next process review." "The full workflow file is in the channel." An open question is allowed when it is genuinely about their process. Never trade a reply for a file, a link or a word.

## HOW WE SHOW A NUMBER

### Never a naked number. WAS, NOW, SAVED.

WAS: 95 minutes a week.

NOW: 22 minutes.

SAVED: 73 minutes, on our own inbox, over four weeks.

Always attach the source of the number and the period it covers. If the number is ours, say "on our own process". If we do not have a number, say "we did not measure this" and describe what we saw instead.

## HOW A SPONSORED RADAR OPENS

### Who paid, what we tested, whose verdict it is.

"This Radar is sponsored by [tool]. They paid for the episode, not for the verdict. We ran it on our own process and the limitations below are the ones we hit."

Plain and first, before the content.

## HOW WE ADMIT FAILURE

### Past tense, first person, specific step.

"We tested it for seven days. We built the version with the approval step. This broke on the third run, when two records had the same company name."

Use "we tested", "we built", "this broke". Keep "client result" for a real client pilot with an agreed baseline and metric.

## ON THE NUMBERS ON THIS PAGE

Every figure above is a placeholder that shows the pattern, taken from the voice file. Never publish a number we have not measured. A missing number is written as "we did not measure this", which is a publishable answer; an invented one is not.

# Naming rules

 DO

## M2 Lab

Capital M, digit 2, space, capital L. The username `m2lab.ai` is always lowercase.

 DO NOT

## M2Lab, m2 lab, M2lab

There is no wordmark. "M2 Lab" set as text next to the mark is never used as a substitute logo. The name appears in copy only, as running text.

### FORMAT NAMES

M2 Radar, M2 Builds, M2 Teardowns. Both words capitalized, with M2 in front on first mention in any piece. After first mention, Radar, Builds and Teardowns are allowed. Builds and Teardowns keep the plural as the format name. A single episode is "a Teardown" or "a Build".

### THE TWO OF US

Michael & Max, in that order, with an ampersand. Michael in public copy, Max in public copy. Never reorder, never abbreviate to initials.

### ON-SCREEN FORMAT TAGS

**RADAR / 04**

**BUILD / 03**

**TEARDOWN / 05**

Uppercase, with the episode number.

### SPELLING

American English across all published copy.

### ALWAYS UPPERCASE

**M2 VERDICT**

**KEEP, TEST, KILL**

**CURRENT, AI LAYER, VERDICT**

The verdict words are uppercase in copy and on screen. CURRENT, AI LAYER and VERDICT are uppercase when they are the three columns of the process scheme.

# Words and constructions we do not publish

Lintner input. Matched case-insensitively on published copy: captions, on-screen text, scripts, bios, carousels, replies. It does not apply to the labeled "do not" examples inside this book.

|               |                            |                     |                               |
|---------------|----------------------------|---------------------|-------------------------------|
| 10x           | you won't believe          | make money with AI  | hack                          |
| 100x          | nobody is talking about    | passive income      | prompt hack                   |
| game-changer  | this changes everything    | \$10k/month         | top 10 AI tools               |
| game changer  | the future of work is here | six figures         | best AI tools                 |
| gamechanger   | AI employee                | guaranteed results  | comment X below               |
| revolutionary | AI workforce               | guaranteed ROI      | comment [WORD]                |
| unlock        | hire an AI                 | helping you master  | type YES below                |
| unleash       | replace your team          | teaching you how to | link in comments              |
| supercharge   | replace your job           | learn AI in         | follow for more               |
| insane        | fully autonomous           | master AI           | save this or you'll regret it |
| mind-blowing  | set it and forget it       | secret              | tag someone who needs this    |

CLAIMS WITHOUT A BASELINE

Any revenue, conversion, retention or cost-saving promise without a published baseline, for example "boost revenue by", "double your leads", "cut costs by", "increase conversion by".

ENGAGEMENT BAIT

"Drop a" plus an emoji or a word in exchange for a reply, in any wording.

PUNCTUATION AND CHARACTERS

No emoji anywhere in published copy, including emoji used as bullets, dividers or punctuation. No long dash character in body copy: use a comma or a full stop.

# Content formats: the three pillars

Three pillars. Education is not a fourth pillar; it lives inside all three.

| PILLAR       | PURPOSE                                                        | CORE AUDIENCE QUESTION                                    | REQUIRED PROOF                                  |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| M2 Radar     | Translate a tool, model or market signal into a work decision. | "Is this solution relevant to me?"                        | A concrete task, a decision, and a limitation.  |
| M2 Builds    | Show a workflow M2 actually built and tested.                  | "What does a first working version look like?"            | Process, result, failure, and human review.     |
| M2 Teardowns | Break down a repeated process before automation.               | "Is this process suitable for AI, and how would it work?" | Inputs, friction, AI boundary, owner, and risk. |

| WHERE THE VERDICT CARD IS REQUIRED                                                                               | CADENCE                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | EACH WEEK ALSO PRODUCES                                                                                                                                                                  |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| In Builds and Teardowns, always. In Radar, whenever we ran the tool ourselves, which should be most of the time. | Five publications a week: 2 M2 Radar, 2 M2 Builds, 1 M2 Teardown. Every second week the fifth slot becomes a second Teardown in place of one Build, so the mix alternates between 2 / 2 / 1 and 2 / 1 / 2. Teardowns never drop below one a week: they are the format that feeds the next Build. | One carousel drawn from the strongest Teardown of the fortnight, and one workshop-channel message with the long version: the workflow file, the prompts, and the part that did not work. |

# Structure at 50 to 60 seconds

The same five beats in all three formats. The bands are targets, not a stopwatch.

Living section. Updated 8 September 2026 from the 1 September radar analysis. Revised after every 12 publications and after each radar run.

| BEAT      | BAND ,<br>SECONDS | RADAR                                                 | BUILDS                                                     | TEARDOWNS                                                            |
|-----------|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hook      | 0-3               | The one work decision this signal forces.             | The thing we ran and how long for.                         | The process and where its time goes.                                 |
| Context   | 3-12              | The task it touches and who owns it today.            | What we were trying to replace, and the baseline.          | The current steps, in order.                                         |
| Proof     | 12-38             | Our own test on one task, plus the limitation we hit. | The screen, the run, and the step that broke.              | The map: CURRENT, AI LAYER, VERDICT, with the step that stays human. |
| Verdict   | 38-50             | KEEP, TEST or KILL, with the condition.               | Verdict Card on screen, plus the WAS / NOW / SAVED number. | Verdict Card on screen: which steps to automate, which not.          |
| Next step | 50-60             | One thing they do in their own work today.            | One thing they do, or the workflow file in the channel.    | One thing they do before their next process review.                  |

BEFORE ANYTHING IS PUBLISHED

| 01                                                              | 02                                               | 03                 | 04                            | 05                                                              | ALL FIVE                    |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Can the topic and the verdict be understood with the sound off? | Is it recognizable as M2 with the handle hidden? | Is the proof ours? | Is a human review step named? | Does the closing line give an action the viewer can take alone? | In order, and all five yes. |

# The editorial filter

■ EVERY REEL MUST MAKE CLEAR

- 1. Which repeated work process is being discussed.
- 2. Where the real friction is.
- 3. What AI should do and what remains human-owned.
- 4. What the viewer should do next.

Do not publish a Reel unless all four are clear. Four yes answers, or it goes back. There is no fifth question that saves a piece.

■ WE DO NOT PUBLISH

- Model news without a practical work decision.
- Generic "top AI tools" lists.
- Deep technical tutorials aimed at developers.
- AI-agent demos without a real process owner.
- Revenue, conversion or time-saving claims without evidence.
- Content about automation for its own sake.
- Somebody else's demo or launch footage as the substance of a piece.
- A request for a comment, a word or a tag in exchange for a file or a link.

ONE PIECE, THREE READERS

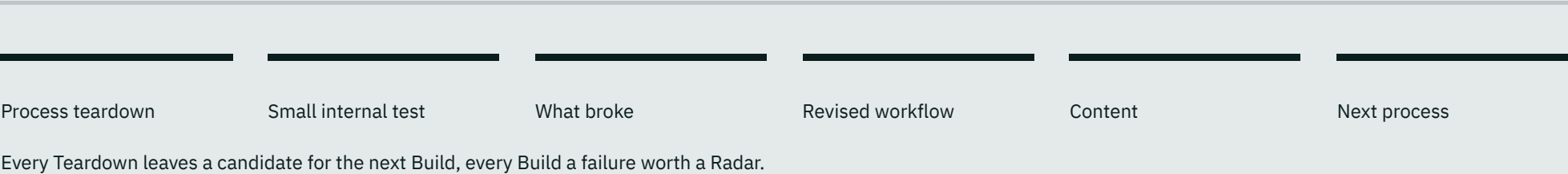
**Owner.** Engaged, and seeing the problem as their own.

**Champion.** Informed, and seeing the solution and the path to it.

**User.** Shown the problem and the solution simply, in their own words.

A Reel shows the problem and the solution, so all three read it.

THE PROOF LOOP



# Messaging hierarchy

Seven levels, from the one sentence that never changes to the line a single post uses once. Use the lowest level that fits the surface. Never put a lower-level line where a higher one belongs.

## LEVEL 1. THE PROMISE

**M2 Lab helps non-technical small-business leaders turn AI confusion into clear, useful everyday work, one workflow at a time, without coding or chasing every new tool.**

## LEVEL 2. SUPPORTING LINE

**Understand what matters. Start with one repeated workflow. Keep a human in control.**

The promise is used whole, or not at all. It is verbatim from the positioning section, with the long dash replaced by a comma per the punctuation rule. The supporting line is the working version of it: the one a caption, a pitch or a reply can carry on its own.

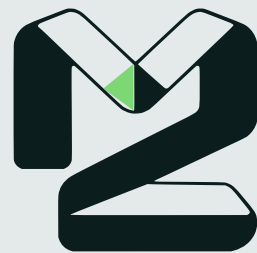
## THE SEVEN LEVELS

- 1 The promise
- 2 Supporting line
- 3 Profile system
- 4 Highlights
- 5 Pinned posts
- 6 Broadcast channel
- 7 Where each level is used

Levels 1 and 2 are brand: they are set here and they change only with the positioning. Levels 3 to 7 are operating detail. They are not in this book; they live in the source file and are handled separately.

# The mark

One primary version: the colour mark, on Paper, with nothing behind it. It is the one centred element in this book, and it is centred because it is a figure, not text.



THE FILE

m2-mark-color.svg on Paper and light photos. On Ink, photo, video or any dark surface, the mono Paper version is used instead: see the next page.

CLEAR SPACE

A quarter of the mark's height, kept on all four sides. Nothing enters this zone: no text, no line, no frame edge, no other logo.

96 px mark: 24 px on every side

620 px mark: 155 px on every side

MINIMUM SIZES

| VERSION | MINIMUM    | BELOW IT                                                               |
|---------|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Colour  | 32 px wide | Switch to mono. The Signal wedge turns to mud below this width.        |
| Mono    | 20 px wide | Do not place the mark at all. Below this it stops reading as the mark. |

PLACEMENT ON STANDARD CANVASES

| CANVAS                          | MARK HEIGHT |
|---------------------------------|-------------|
| Reel and Story cover, 1080x1920 | 120 px      |
| Feed canvases                   | 96 px       |
| Avatar, 1080x1080 circle        | 620 px      |

On 9:16, place the mark bottom-right, inside Zone A, using the frame's own padding as the origin.

# The mark: what is and is not done with it

THE MARK IS ALWAYS

- scaled proportionally on both axes, never stretched;
- upright, never rotated, tilted, outlined, or boxed in a frame;
- one of the two approved versions, never a third colour;
- placed on a flat tone or an Ink plate, never directly on a busy part of a photo;
- flat like the rest of the system: no shadow, no glow, no rounded corners.

REJECT IF

- proportions are not uniform;
- the mark is rotated, tilted, outlined, or framed;
- a colour outside the two files is used;
- it sits on a busy photo area with no flat tone or Ink plate behind it;
- a shadow, glow, or rounded corner has been added.

ON DARK SURFACES



On Ink, photo, video and any dark surface, the mono Paper version is used. The colour mark on Ink is invisible: its silhouette is the same colour as the background.

NO WORDMARK

Decision of 8 September 2026. There is no wordmark. Setting "M2 Lab" as text next to the mark is never used as a substitute logo. The name appears in copy only, as running text.

REJECTED VERSION

An inverse version was rejected on 4 September 2026: it was not liked visually, and its function is already covered by the mono Paper version. It is kept in the rejected library with its rationale and the matching SVG.

GEOMETRY

Geometry is untouchable. Only the colour values follow the tokens; the paths themselves never change between the two files.

PROVENANCE

The supplied SVG was an autotrace of a raster: one black shape, light facets as holes, no Signal wedge in the file. The mark was rebuilt in layers, meaning silhouette, facets and wedge, with contours inherited from the trace. If the original vector is found, rebuild the mark from it so the curves are clean and the wedge is a true shape.

PART 2

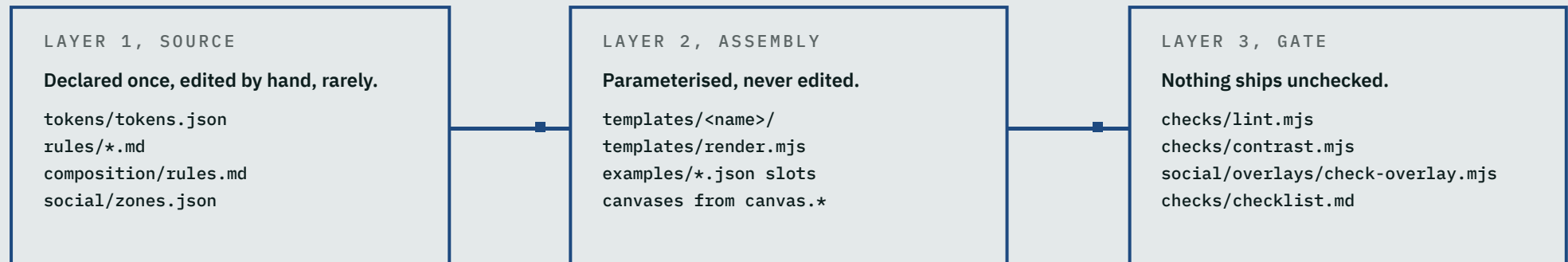
# Design system

The values the work is built from, and the rules that keep every frame recognisable.



# How the system works

Three layers, one direction of travel. Values are declared once, assembled into artefacts by template, and checked by script before anything is published.



A VALUE MOVES LEFT TO RIGHT ONLY. NOTHING DOWNSTREAM MAY INVENT ONE.

## The law

**Reusable things are parameterised, never edited.** Values come only from `tokens/tokens.json`, and anything carrying letters or the mark is built from a template so it is reproducible, editable and positioned exactly.

A frame that was nudged by hand cannot be rebuilt, so it is not an asset of the system. Rejected work goes to `library/rejected/` with a one-line reason; approved renders go to `library/approved/`.

- A value not in `tokens.json` is an error, not a choice.
- A layout that cannot be rebuilt from its slot file does not enter the library.
- A check that has not been run is a check that failed.

## WHERE THINGS LIVE

|                           |                                              |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| <code>tokens/</code>      | values, and everything built from them       |
| <code>rules/</code>       | colour, type, layout, icons, imagery, motion |
| <code>stickers/</code>    | fifty sticker components in ten families     |
| <code>composition/</code> | five sources, and the not-this list          |
| <code>social/</code>      | placements, zones, QA overlays               |
| <code>templates/</code>   | renderable artefacts                         |
| <code>checks/</code>      | linter, contrast, checklist                  |
| <code>research/</code>    | the measurements behind the values           |
| <code>library/</code>     | approved and rejected renders                |
| <code>brand/</code>       | positioning, voice, formats, the mark        |

# Composition rules: where things go

These are the rules for placing text, numbers, icons and marks in a frame. Each rule comes from one of five references we borrow techniques from, so the frames look made by hand, not generated.

| REFERENCE                  | WHAT IT IS                                                                                       | TECHNIQUES, AND WHERE THEY SHOW UP                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Engineering drawing</b> | A technical drawing made to be read by whoever builds the thing, not to be admired.              | Put every label next to the object, never on top of it, and connect it with a thin line ending in a dot. Used on the verdict card and the data slide.<br>Use red only for what is broken or wrong. Used on the verdict card's KILL mark.           |
| <b>Isotype</b>             | A picture-statistics system that shows a quantity by repeating one icon, never by resizing it.   | Show a count by repeating one icon at one size, never a bigger icon for a bigger number. Used on the data slide.<br>Draw an empty outline for a unit that is gone, so the drop reads without a caption. Used on the data slide and the list slide. |
| <b>Swiss grid</b>          | A mid-century grid system that shows importance through size and weight, never through centring. | Line up every element to the left edge, with a small gap off the guide, and centre nothing. Used on the cover and the lower third.<br>Make the important thing bigger or bolder, never a different colour. Used on the cover.                      |
| <b>Oscilloscope</b>        | A measurement display that marks one point on a trace and never lets a number stand by itself.   | Point a marker exactly at the number under discussion and label it right beside it. Used on the cover's metric.<br>Always name what a number was, is now, and what it saved. Used on the data slide.                                               |
| <b>Checklist</b>           | An operational list where the state of each line reads from its shape, not only its colour.      | Show done, blocked or pending as a different shape, not just a different colour. Used on the verdict card.<br>Give every item its own line, and never let one item wrap onto two. Used on the list slide.                                          |

**The rule.** If a placement cannot be traced to one of these five, it is changed or removed.

SOURCE FILE  
composition/rules.md

# Colour, the seven values

Seven colours, one source: `tokens/tokens.json`. No colour appears anywhere in the system that is not one of these, and each carries one meaning for the whole piece.

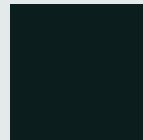


## Paper

#E4E9EA  
color.base.  
paper

**Does.** Carries the primary surface of covers, carousels, documents and the avatar.

**Never.** Never sits as text on a light surface.



## Ink

#0C1D1D  
color.base.  
ink

**Does.** Sets all text on Paper, and forms the dark surface for Reel covers and plates.

**Never.** Never becomes the default ground for feed work.



## Signal

#7DD774  
color.base.  
signal

**Does.** Lights data and the KEEP state on Ink, and colours the mark.

**Never.** Never appears as text, and never on Paper outside the mark.



## Oxide

#BB4347  
color.base.  
oxide

**Does.** Marks what is broken, at risk, or KILL.

**Never.** Never carries a mood, a heading or a chart series.



## Blueprint

#1E4A80  
color.base.  
blueprint

**Does.** Draws structure: arrows, boxes, leader lines, chart series two.

**Never.** Never states a verdict or a value judgement.

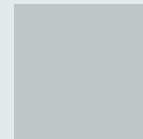


## Graphite

#5C6565  
color.base.  
graphite

**Does.** Sets secondary text on Paper; muted grid lines on Ink.

**Never.** Never sets text on Ink, at 2.9:1.



## Rule

#BEC6C7  
color.base.  
rule

**Does.** Draws the hairline divider on Paper.

**Never.** Never carries text or an icon stroke.

The Paper chip carries a Graphite hairline so its edge shows on this page. Permitted pairs and their ratios follow.

# Colour rules

Ratios are computed by `checks/contrast.mjs` and stored in `checks/out/contrast.json`. Text pairs need 4.5:1, graphic pairs 3:1.

## ALLOWED PAIRS, TEXT, 4.5:1

|                   |         |
|-------------------|---------|
| Ink on Paper      | 14.18:1 |
| Paper on Ink      | 14.18:1 |
| Graphite on Paper | 4.89:1  |
| Rule on Ink       | 10:1    |

## ALLOWED PAIRS, GRAPHIC, 3:1

|                                |        |
|--------------------------------|--------|
| Signal on Ink                  | 9.80:1 |
| Blueprint on Paper             | 7.31:1 |
| Rule on Ink, lines             | 10:1   |
| Oxide on Paper                 | 4.28:1 |
| Oxide on Ink, at 4 px or wider | 3.31:1 |

## FORBIDDEN

Signal as text on Paper, 1.45:1. Oxide as text on Ink, graphic threshold only. Signal as text anywhere: it states data and the mark, never a voice.

## SURFACE RULE, PAPER FIRST

Build every artefact on Paper first: the light surface is what takes the system off the near-black plus one accent cluster. Ink is reserved for three jobs, Reel covers, flat plates under text over footage, and the Verdict Card on video.

Feed cover, 4:5 and 1:1      Paper throughout; Ink only as type, rule and mark

Reel cover, 9:16      Ink ground permitted in full; Signal allowed here only

Carousel, 10 slides      Paper on every slide; at most one Ink slide, the verdict

Story      Paper by default; Ink only as a plate under text

Avatar      Paper with the monochrome Ink mark, 1.45:1 in colour

Highlight cover      Paper ground, Ink icon, inside the 54 px circle inset

## WHAT EACH COLOUR MEANS

- Oxide means broken, out of tolerance or KILL, and nothing else in any frame.
- Signal means lit data on a dark field, plus the mark itself.
- Blueprint means structure: arrows, boxes, leader lines, second-level fills.
- Hierarchy is built with size, weight and position, so colour is free to carry meaning, one meaning per colour.

## COLOUR BLINDNESS, MACHADO 2009 AT SEVERITY 1.0

| VISION       | LIGHTNESS GAP | SEPARABLE |
|--------------|---------------|-----------|
| normal       | 0.249         | yes       |
| deuteranopia | 0.239         | yes       |
| protanopia   | 0.355         | yes       |

Oxide against Signal. Every state is also encoded in the shape of its frame, so it survives when the hues collapse into one.

# Why this palette

The 4 September palette was approved and then measured. It carried all three markers of the near-black plus one accent cluster, so the brief was to spread it, not redesign it.

FIVE REASONS, IN ORDER OF EFFECT

- The surface moved first. Flipping the primary surface to Paper removes the cluster silhouette before any hue argument is needed.
- The mark stays green. The change is chroma and lightness, not identity, so recognisability against the approved palette survives.
- The accent is de-neoned measurably. Signal drops from chroma 0.206 to 0.16 and lightness 0.916 to 0.8, and still returns 9.80:1 on Ink.
- Two accents plus structure. Blueprint gives diagrams a voice that is neither Signal nor Oxide, which stops a page reading as one bright thing on black.
- It is the smallest move that works. Secondary text also stops failing: Graphite goes from 4.20:1 to 4.89:1, clearing the 4.5:1 text threshold.

Distances are OKLCH hue degrees and OKLab colour difference. B is the fallback if an Ink-first surface turns out to be non-negotiable for Reel covers. C fails colour-blind separation and is documented, not proposed.

THE FOUR VARIANTS MEASURED

| VARIANT                  | COLOURS | ACCENT HUE | ALERT HUE | PAPER | FAILS |
|--------------------------|---------|------------|-----------|-------|-------|
| Approved 4 Sep           | 6       | 0°         | 2°        | 0.024 | 1     |
| A, Oxide, adopted        | 7       | 15.3°      | 7.2°      | 0.031 | 0     |
| B, Amber, fallback       | 7       | 41.7°      | 14°       | 0.037 | 0     |
| C, Instrument, on record | 7       | 73.3°      | 16.9°     | 0.027 | 0     |

Accent hue measured off acid green, alert hue off vermilion, Paper off cream. Full workings in `research/palette-options.md`.

WHAT THIS COSTS, AND WHAT IT DOES NOT FIX

**Every Ink-background template is re-cut for Paper.** The real price of the move, and a production cost rather than a design one.

**Signal on Paper is a fill, not a text colour.** At 1.45:1 it always carries Ink text on top and never sits as type itself.

**The logo minimum size is unchanged.** The colour mark on Paper stays invisible, so the monochrome Ink mark remains mandatory on light surfaces.

**Oxide on Ink clears 3:1 only just, at 3.31:1.** Check the swatch sheet after a round trip through Instagram compression.

# Typography, the specimen

HOOK, 96 PX ON CANVAS, SHOWN AT 0.361 OF CANVAS, THE PHONE SCALE

We replaced the weekly report

SAIRA SEMICONDENSED BLACK 900, 1.03, -0.01em, 20 CHARACTERS A LINE

THE HIGHLIGHT DEVICE, LIVE

We stopped the weekly report

KEY PHRASE ON AN INK PLATE, PAPER TEXT, ON A PAPER SURFACE

On Ink the plate is Signal with Ink text. Oxide only when the phrase names something broken. Never italics, never a second family.

TITLE 72, BODY 46, SUBTITLE 40, LABEL 36

Four minutes, not four hours

The run took four minutes, against two hours by hand.

We ran it again with the log open.

M2 RADAR / 04

SAIRA EXTRABOLD 800, THEN PLEX SANS 400, PLEX SANS SEMIBOLD 600, PLEX MONO 500

THE DISPLAY FACE

 Saira SemiCondensed

WHY THIS FACE

Flat-sided bowls, terminals cut horizontally: every edge of the mark is a straight segment on a hard mitre.

At 900 the stem sits near the mark's 0.239 stem ratio; a 700 Bold reads thin beside it.

21.2 characters per 888 px line at 96 px, against Plex Condensed's 21.3, so every size token stands.

| ROLE        | TOKEN                  | FAMILY AND CUT                    | SIZE         | LEAD | TRACK   | CHARS | USED ON                                 |
|-------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------|--------------|------|---------|-------|-----------------------------------------|
| Hook        | size.hook.*            | Saira SemiCondensed Black 900     | 90/96/104 px | 1.03 | -0.01em | 20    | Covers, carousel slide one, reel opener |
| Hook 4:5    | size.hook.fallback-4x5 | Saira SemiCondensed Black 900     | 84 px        | 1.03 | -0.01em | 20    | 1080x1350 only, escape hatch            |
| Title       | size.title.default     | Saira SemiCondensed ExtraBold 800 | 72 px        | 1.03 | -0.01em | 20    | Carousel titles, lower-third names      |
| Body        | size.body.*            | IBM Plex Sans Regular 400         | 52/46/42 px  | 1.35 | 0em     | 38    | Statement lead, lists, proof, sources   |
| Subtitle    | size.caption.default   | IBM Plex Sans SemiBold 600        | 40 px        | 1.2  | 0em     | 38    | Burned-in subtitles on reels, stories   |
| Label       | size.label.default     | IBM Plex Mono Medium 500          | 36 px        | 1.0  | 0.16em  | 20    | Format tags, verdict chips, axis labels |
| Label small | size.label.small       | IBM Plex Mono Medium 500          | 32 px        | 1.0  | 0.16em  | 20    | Episode numbers and metadata only       |

TITLE REUSES THE HOOK LEADING AND TRACKING. PLEX SANS CONDENSED IS ONLY THE FALLBACK CUT INSIDE FONT.FAMILY.DISPLAY

# Typography rules

The binding constraint is characters per line, not word count. Every figure below is measured against the real font files in `research/heading-font.md`.

## THE HOOK

- Write 6 to 8 words on 9:16 and 6 words on 4:5: the 4:5 band leaves only 34 px of slack at four lines, against 542 px on 9:16.
- Hold every line to 20 characters in the 888 px column. Two short words can overflow while two long ones fit.
- Cut words when a hook does not fit, and keep the size at 90 px or above.
- Use the 84 px fallback on 1080x1350 only, and only when a hook cannot be shortened to 6 words.
- Set the hook left on the grid with the 24 px indent, never flush and never centred.
- Draw one 4 px rule under the hook block as the single permitted ornament on a cover.

## CASE

Sentence case for hooks and titles. Caps only for tags and stickers. Hierarchy comes from size and weight, never from case.

## PUNCTUATION

- Commas and full stops; no long dashes.
- Meta joins on a slash and a space; no middle dots.
- A button ends in its own words; no arrow glyphs.
- Emphasis is a heavier weight, never italic.

## THE PLATE, THE ONLY HIGHLIGHT DEVICE

Put the key phrase of a hook on a plate when it needs a second beat. The plate is a shape behind the words, not a colour change to the text, so it is not colour hierarchy.



Never italics, never a second family, and no plate colour outside Ink, Signal and Oxide.

## A LABEL IS NOT AN EYEBROW

A tracked-out caps line sitting above every heading as decoration is a named generated-page tell, and it does not appear here. Our labels are a format tag with a number, an axis label, or a verdict chip, each on its own grid slot and each appearing once, because it identifies the frame.

## NUMBERS ARE NEVER NAKED

Every number carries its WAS, NOW or SAVED label in Mono at label size. A bare number does not ship.

|       |            |
|-------|------------|
| WAS   | 4 h 20 min |
| NOW   | 6 min      |
| SAVED | 4 h 14 min |

## LEGIBILITY, A REEL IN FEED ON A 390 PX PHONE

| ROLE         | CANVAS | ON PHONE |
|--------------|--------|----------|
| Hook         | 96px   | 34.67    |
| Body lead    | 52px   | 18.78    |
| Body default | 46px   | 16.61    |
| Body small   | 42px   | 15.17    |
| Subtitle     | 40px   | 14.44    |
| Label        | 36px   | 13.00    |
| Label small  | 32px   | 11.56    |

CSS px at scale 0.3611. The subtitle clears the 14 px subtitle floor, the label clears the 12 px floor, and label small at 11.56 is the smallest size the system allows.

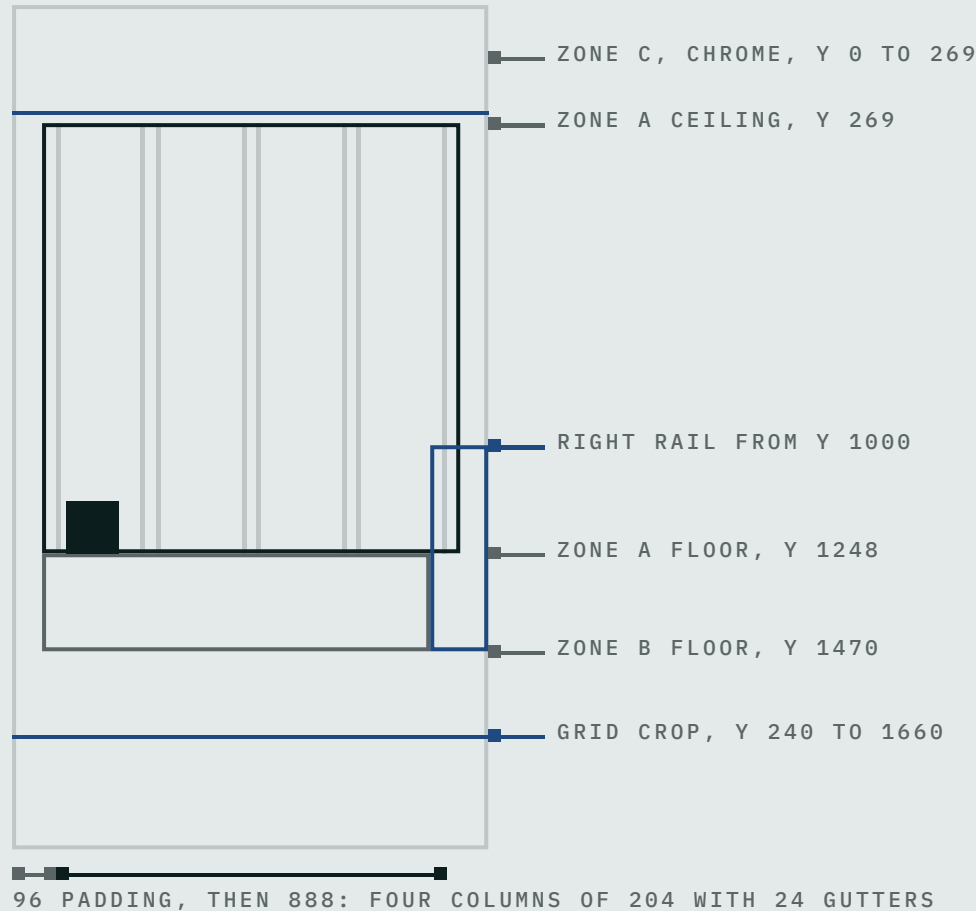
These figures hold unchanged under Saira: 21.2 characters per 888 px line at 96 px, against Plex Condensed's 21.3, so the size tokens and the 20-character lint constant carry over.

## THE GRID TILE IS NOT FOR READING

Treat the 3:4 profile tile as a visual frame. Even a 104 px hook reaches only 8.40 CSS px of cap height there, below the 9 px bar, so shape, surface and the mark carry it.

# Layout and the grid

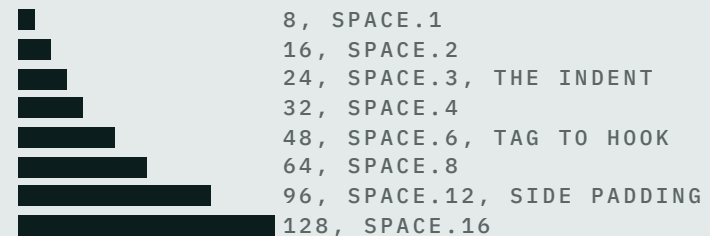
One grid, one indent, one spacing scale. The frame below is drawn at 0.22 of the 1080x1920 canvas; every number beside it is the canvas value in pixels, from `tokens.json` and `social/zones.json`.



## THE RULES THAT HOLD IT

- Lay 4 columns of 204 px with a 24 px gutter inside 96 px side padding, giving an 888 px text column.
- Snap every element to a column guide and set text 24 px right of it, never flush.
- Hook, mark, format tag, claim bar and Verdict Card live in Zone A only. Zone B takes burned-in subtitles and nothing else, down to y 1470. Zone C takes nothing.
- Keep the 130 px right rail empty below y 1000.
- Draw every corner square: no radius, no shadow, no gradient. Two stroke widths exist, 2 px and 4 px.

## THE SPACING SCALE, DRAWN AT FULL SIZE

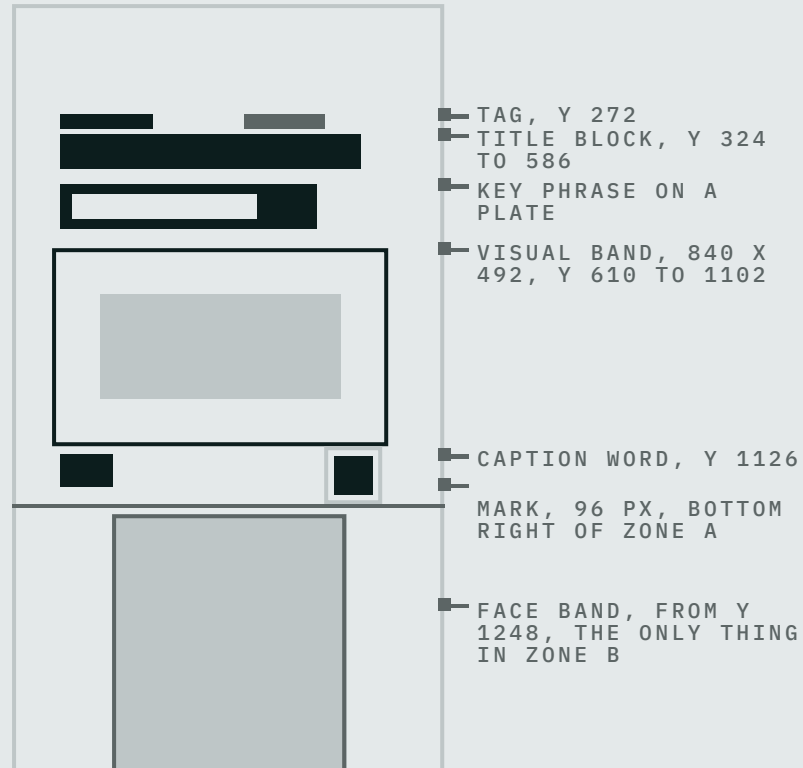


Only these eight steps exist. No value between them is used anywhere in the system. The solid square inside the frame is the mark at 120 px, on the indent, its baseline on the Zone A floor.

# Canvases and the slot map

Eight canvases, one slot map. The cover below is drawn at 0.2 of 1080 by 1920. Slots hold their position for the whole piece, so a returning viewer already knows where to look.

## THE STANDARD COVER, SLOT BY SLOT



The Graphite line across the frame is the Zone A floor at y 1248. Everything above it carries meaning; the face placeholder starts on it and runs to the bottom edge.

## THE EIGHT CANVASES

|             |           |                                     |
|-------------|-----------|-------------------------------------|
| Reel        | 1080x1920 | Reels and their covers              |
| Story       | 1080x1920 | Stories, same safe zone             |
| Feed        | 1080x1350 | The default feed post, 4:5 portrait |
| Feed tall   | 1080x1440 | 3:4 upload, never cropped           |
| Feed square | 1080x1080 | Square posts, swatch sheets square  |
| Carousel    | 1080x1350 | Every slide of a carousel           |
| Avatar      | 1080x1080 | Profile picture, circle crop        |
| Highlight   | 1080x1920 | Highlight cover, circle crop        |

## CROPS, THE OTHER THING THAT REMOVES CONTENT

The 3:4 profile tile keeps y 240 to 1660 of a 9:16 cover, so tag, title, visual band and caption word all survive it. Feed tiles lose 34 px a side from 4:5 and 135 px from 1:1, and nothing from 3:4. Circle crops keep content 54 px inside the 1080 square.

## CAROUSEL

- Build 2 to 10 slides, all at 1080x1350 and all identical in pixel size: the first slide sets the ratio and later slides are cropped to match without warning.
- Place the page indicator bottom left on the indent as one identical 16 px square per slide, 8 px apart, current filled and the rest outlined.
- Use nine slide types and no tenth: cover, statement, list, Isotype data, before and after, scheme, proof, verdict, next step.
- Paper on every slide, and at most one Ink slide, which is the verdict.

Show one instrument at a time in the band below y 1000, so the claim bar, the Verdict Card and the lower third never share a frame.

# Instagram safe zones

Zone A is always safe and takes the hook, mark, Verdict Card and format label. Zone B is organic only and takes burned-in subtitles. Zone C takes nothing with meaning.

THE EIGHT QA MASKS FROM SOCIAL/OVERLAYS/, AT ABOUT A THIRTEENTH OF SIZE



| PLACEMENT       | CANVAS    | ZONE A, X Y W H      | WHAT THE GRID DOES | CONFIDENCE    |
|-----------------|-----------|----------------------|--------------------|---------------|
| reel            | 1080x1920 | 65,269,950,979       | y 240 to 1660      | meta-official |
| story           | 1080x1920 | 65,269,950,979       | not shown in grid  | meta-official |
| feed-portrait   | 1080x1350 | 48,48,984,1254       | 34 px per side     | practice      |
| feed-tall       | 1080x1440 | 48,48,984,1344       | none, exact match  | practice      |
| feed-square     | 1080x1080 | 135,0,810,1080       | 135 px per side    | derived       |
| carousel        | 1080x1350 | 48,48,984,1254       | 34 px per side     | practice      |
| avatar          | 1080x1080 | circle 540,540 r 486 | circle crop        | derived       |
| highlight-cover | 1080x1920 | circle 540,960 r 486 | circle crop        | derived       |

Only the Reel has a Zone B, at 65,1248,885,222, secondary. Meta-official is a live Meta ad-spec page, derived means the arithmetic is in `zones.json`, practice means agency convention.

- WHAT META DOES NOT PUBLISH
- The pixel box for the Reels right-side action-button column.
  - Coordinates for Stories interactive stickers, described only as middle lower.
  - Whether the Stories bottom margin is 35 per cent or the older 20 per cent. The live pages say 35, so 672 px is what we use.
  - The displayed avatar circle size, disputed across 32 to 150 px, and any safe inset percentage.
  - The displayed highlight-cover diameter, disputed at 110, 161 and about 700 px. We design for 110.
  - The crop applied to a Reel playing inline in a follower's main feed.
  - Any numeric subtitle placement guidance beyond the retired 20 per cent text-overlay rule.

# Stickers, the library

A sticker names a format, marks a state, points at a step, frames a number or stands in for a screen. Sixty-five of them in eleven families, each a plain SVG with live editable text.



STICKERS/SHEET.PNG, 2200 BY 3600,  
RENDERED FROM THE REAL SVGS.  
SOURCE SHEET.HTML, INDEX  
MANIFEST.JSON

## ELEVEN FAMILIES: TEN OF FIVE, PLUS THE INK VARIANTS

| FAMILY                            | WHAT IT DOES, AND WHEN IT IS USED                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>a. Tags 01-05</b>              | Names the format and the episode. Four plates, plus the M2 VERDICT header.                                                        |
| <b>b. Highlights 06-10</b>        | One key phrase of a hook. Ink bar, Signal bar, underline, bracket, Oxide for what broke.                                          |
| <b>c. Callouts 11-15</b>          | Pulls the label off the object on a leader line ending in a square point. Four directions.                                        |
| <b>d. Verdict and state 16-20</b> | States the call. KEEP, KILL and TEST chips, the source stamp, the Oxide marker.                                                   |
| <b>e. Numbers 21-25</b>           | The only frames a number ships in: WAS NOW SAVED, a big number and its unit, a delta, a counter, a share with its baseline.       |
| <b>f. Lists 26-30</b>             | Structure without arrowheads: numbered rows, checklist, step chain, ranked row.                                                   |
| <b>g. Data 31-35</b>              | A measurement with its axes: a Signal line card, two bars on one scale, a watch-time bar, an isotype row, an oscilloscope cursor. |
| <b>h. Screens 36-40</b>           | Frames a real capture: phone at 9:16, browser, script card, document card, terminal card. A screenshot, never stock.              |
| <b>i. People and roles 41-45</b>  | Who is speaking and who owns the step: lower third, role chip, human-review plate, cutout frame, attributable quote.              |
| <b>j. Meta 46-50</b>              | The small print on a cover: view count, runtime badge, swipe units, the sound-off note, the source plate.                         |
| <b>k. Ink variants 51-65</b>      | The fifteen structural stickers redrawn for an Ink ground: same geometry, same slots, text in Paper.                              |

Pick the variant by surface, never recolour a sticker by hand. An Ink-drawn file goes blind on an Ink ground, so on Ink take the matching file from family k instead.

Editable strings are <text> elements with id="slot-name": the type stays live and the file stays diffable.

# Sticker placement and glyphs

A sticker is placed on the grid, at one of two scales, with one accent per frame. Lucide icons survive only as glyphs inside a sticker, under the stroke rule in [rules/iconography.md](#).

## PLACEMENT

- **Grid.** Snap the left edge of a sticker to a guide of the four-column grid, then push it off the guide by the 24 px indent. Nothing is centred and nothing is flush.
- **Scale.** Place at 1x where the file already fits, and at 1.5x where the frame needs it. Scale a whole sticker, never one part of it, and correct the stroke back to 2 px or 4 px, the only two widths the system has.
- **Size to the canvas.** On 1080 px: a tag or chip is 6 to 12 percent of canvas height, a card or a screen 30 to 45 percent, a highlight bar spans 60 to 90 percent of the text column.
- **Stacking.** Two stickers in one frame share a left edge and keep a 24 px gutter. Three or more means the frame is doing too much.

## ONE ACCENT PER FRAME

- A frame carries either Signal or Oxide, never both and never twice. Blueprint is structure and does not count as an accent.
- Signal appears in stickers 01, 05, 07, 23, 31, 33, 35, 40 and 41, and every one of those is an Ink-surface sticker, because Signal never appears on Paper outside the mark.
- **Oxide only for what is broken.** Stickers 06, 17 and 20 are the only Oxide stickers, and they go on a step that actually failed or a call that was actually killed.
- A number ships inside 21, 22, 23 or 25, or with the source plate 50. A bare number does not ship.

## LUCIDE GLYPHS, INSIDE A STICKER ONLY

Lucide 1.41.0, outline only, on its native 24 by 24 grid, and never on a frame by itself. Resizing scales the stroke with it, so set **stroke-width = 48 / size** to hold the stroke at 2 px: 1.5 at 32 px, 1.0 at 48 px, 0.75 at 64 px, 0.5 at 96 px. Nothing below 32 px goes on the canvas, and at 32 px and 48 px use the 3 px canvas floor instead, 2.25 and 1.5, because a 2 px hairline becomes 0.72 CSS px on a phone. One glyph per line of text, never as decoration, and quantity is shown by repeating one glyph at one size, never by resizing it.

## THE VERDICT SHAPES, 160 BY 56 PX

| VERDICT | FILL      | STROKE                   | LABEL |
|---------|-----------|--------------------------|-------|
| KEEP    | Ink solid | none                     | Paper |
| KILL    | none      | Oxide, 4 px              | Ink   |
| TEST    | none      | Ink, 2 px, dash 12 gap 8 | Ink   |



Every label is Plex Mono 36 px, and the three match in width because Plex Mono is monospaced. Shape first, colour second: the verdict reads with the colour taken away. On an Ink surface the KEEP fill is Signal and its label is Ink.

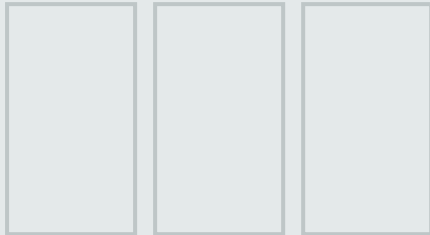
## REJECT IF

- A sticker is centred, or flush to the guide without the indent.
- One part of a sticker is scaled on its own, or a stroke lands on a value other than 2 px or 4 px.
- Oxide marks anything that is not broken, or a frame carries two accents.
- A Lucide glyph stands on a frame outside a sticker, or below 32 px on the canvas.

# Imagery

Every frame serves one formula: a human face, real proof, one labelled verdict. Three shot types exist and there is no fourth. The frames below are placeholders; the real stills come from the library.

## THE THREE SHOT TYPES, 9:16, IN ORDER



[PHOTO: person to camera]

[PHOTO: screen as proof]

[PHOTO: split, proof over person]

## WHAT THE CAMERA SHOWS

- **Person to camera.** One person, static frame, speaking to the lens.
- **Screen as proof.** The workflow, run or artifact, filmed off a monitor or captured natively.
- **Split, proof over person.** Screen above, person below, one grid line between them.
- Hold the shot. The niche median is 0.12 cuts per second.
- Frame the eyes at about y 560, with about 80 px of headroom above the crown.

## LIGHT AND COLOUR ON SET

- Light from one direction only, so shadows fall the same way across a piece.
- Set white balance neutral and record the value, so two shooting days match.
- Shoot against a flat wall or a real workspace, with nothing behind the person but the proof.
- Grade at the timeline with Ink and Paper as the black and white points.
- Grain at the timeline at about 30 per cent, never baked into a source asset.

## SCREENS AS PROOF

- Capture at native resolution and scale down only.
- Keep the cursor visible. It proves a person is driving the run.
- Cover real data with a flat Ink plate at the field's exact bounds, never a blur.
- Snap the rectangle to the grid, left on the indent, top on a grid line.
- One callout at a time, and every number carries WAS, NOW or SAVED.

## GENERATED, STOCK AND PROVENANCE

- Use generated output for backgrounds and B-roll only. Anything with letters or the mark comes from a template.
- Keep it flat and textural: paper grain, concrete, brushed metal, plotted line work, sensor noise.
- Keep letters, people, logos and UI out of a generated frame.
- Record origin, shot or stock or generated with tool and date, when the asset enters the library. It is the only source of truth.
- Use stock only with origin and licence filled at import, held to the same shot and grade rules.
- Shoot both founders on the same 35 mm lens, distance, crop and eye line.

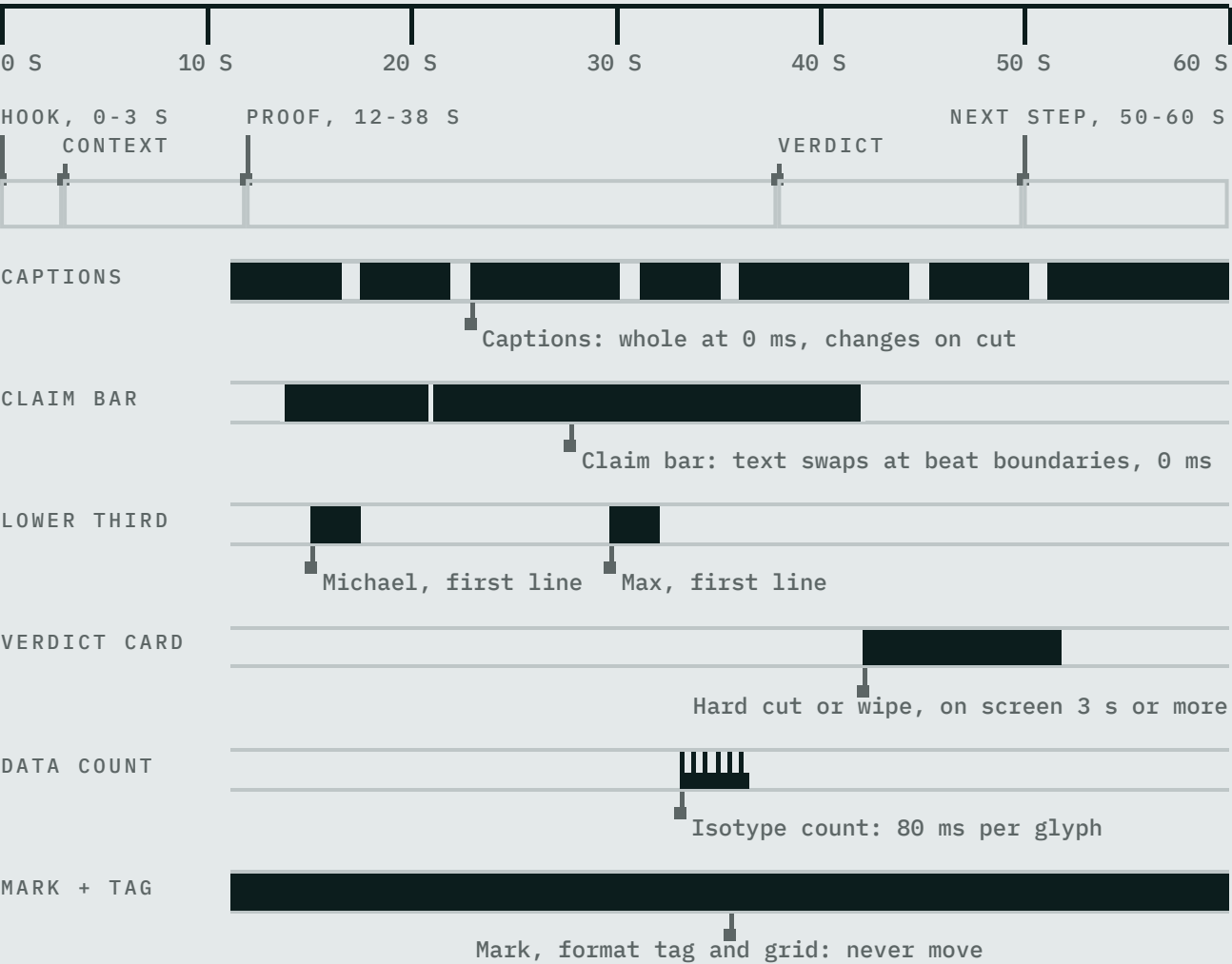
## REJECT IF

- The face or the screen crosses out of the band y 269 to 1248.
- A number appears without WAS, NOW or SAVED.
- Real data is hidden by a soft blur instead of a flat Ink plate.
- The cursor is missing from a screen presented as a run.
- A generated frame contains letters, a person, a logo or UI.
- The origin field is empty, or was filled by guessing from the image.
- Grain or grade is baked into a source asset.
- Oxide is used for anything other than what is broken or KILL.

# Motion

One easing, linear: an instrument moves at a constant rate. Every entrance is keyed to a beat change, never to decoration.

REEL TIMELINE, 0 TO 60 S: FIVE BEATS, SIX OVERLAY LANES



| DURATIONS AND EASING, MOTION TOKENS |         |                    |
|-------------------------------------|---------|--------------------|
| TOKEN                               | VALUE   | USED BY            |
| instant                             | 0 ms    | Captions, cuts     |
| quick                               | 120 ms  | Wipe, Verdict Card |
| standard                            | 200 ms  | Lower third        |
| hold                                | 400 ms  | Min. dwell         |
| isotype-step                        | 80 ms   | Count step         |
| verdict-min                         | 3000 ms | Verdict hold       |
| easing.default                      | linear  | All motion         |

- TRANSITIONS
- Cut hard between shots by default.
  - The 120 ms wipe along a grid line is the only alternative.
  - Captions appear whole at 0 ms, never typewriter.
  - Emphasis moves by weight, SemiBold to Bold, not by colour.
  - Subtitles: 40 px, 2 lines, in Zone A or Zone B.
  - Nothing fades, and nothing slides up.

# Templates: Reel covers

The cover is the still frame a person sees before they tap, and its only job is to give a reason to stop. It states the claim in words readable at thumb size, and beside them it puts one object built from our stickers.

THE FIVE THINGS ON EVERY COVER, IN ORDER DOWN THE FRAME

Y 272

**Tag.** Format and episode on one Mono line.

Y 324

**Title.** Two lines at 96 px, the key phrase on a plate.

Y 610

**Visual.** An 840 by 492 band, one dominant object from a sticker.

Y 1126

**Caption word.** One lowercase word in the display face.

Y 1248

**Presenter.** Face placeholder, a real still, to the bottom edge.

The first four stop at y 1248, the top 65 per cent of the frame and the safe zone: it survives the profile grid and stays clear of the caption, the handle and the action rail Instagram draws over the video. The face sits below the line, where that interface overlaps, because a face is not information.

SIX COVERS, THREE ON PAPER AND THREE ON INK, AT 36 MM WIDE



RADAR / 04, Paper.  
Step chain 28

BUILD / 03, Paper.  
Number set 21

TEARDOWN / 05, Paper.  
Checklist 27

RADAR / 06, Ink. Bar  
card 32

BUILD / 07, Ink.  
Chart card 31

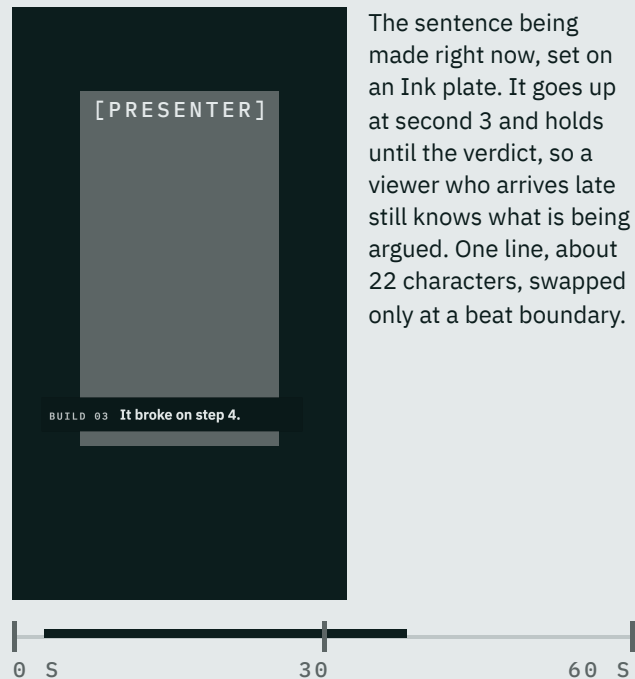
TEARDOWN / 08, Ink.  
Terminal 40

**The grid tile.** The profile grid shows a 3:4 slice, y 240 to 1660, so tag, title, visual and caption word all survive it. **One dominant element.** One object carries the visual band, redrawn from its sticker at 1.5x to 2x until its painted box covers 85 per cent of the 840 width and 80 per cent of the 492 height, with at most one supporting sticker under it.

# Templates: what goes on top of the video

While a person talks to camera, three things are laid over the footage. Each answers a question the viewer would otherwise have to guess, each has a fixed slot and a fixed moment, and only one of them is on screen at a time. Below, each one is shown on a frame with the presenter standing in as a grey block.

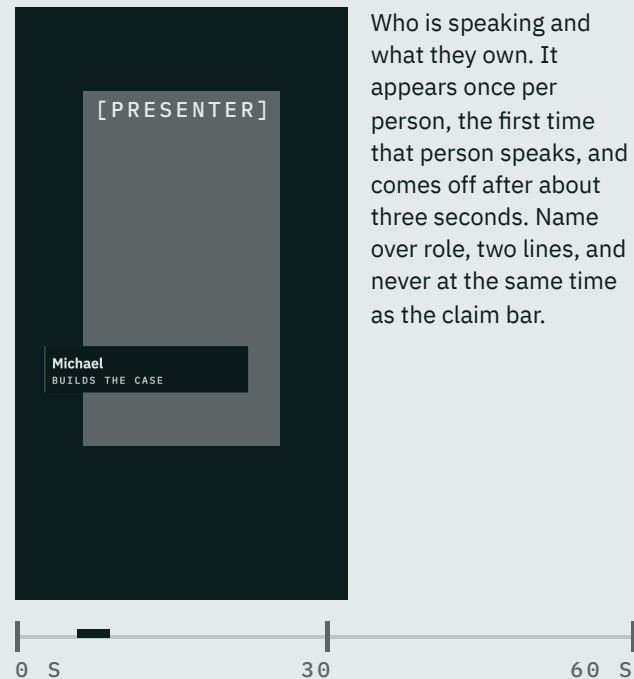
## 1. CLAIM BAR



The sentence being made right now, set on an Ink plate. It goes up at second 3 and holds until the verdict, so a viewer who arrives late still knows what is being argued. One line, about 22 characters, swapped only at a beat boundary.

On from 0:03 to the verdict. Plate on the 96 guide at y 1264, 840 wide, top of Zone B

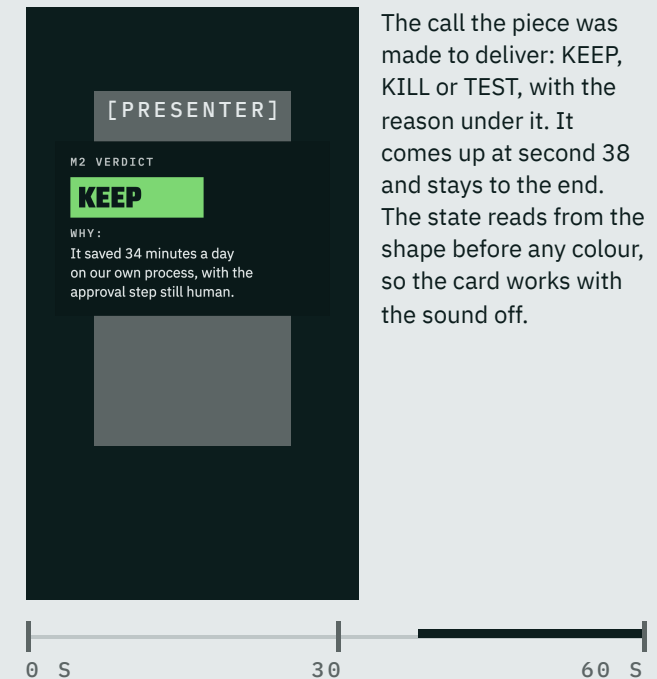
## 2. LOWER THIRD



Who is speaking and what they own. It appears once per person, the first time that person speaks, and comes off after about three seconds. Name over role, two lines, and never at the same time as the claim bar.

On for about 3 s at the first line each person speaks. Plate bottom on the Zone A floor, y 1248

## 3. VERDICT CARD



The call the piece was made to deliver: KEEP, KILL or TEST, with the reason under it. It comes up at second 38 and stays to the end. The state reads from the shape before any colour, so the card works with the sound off.

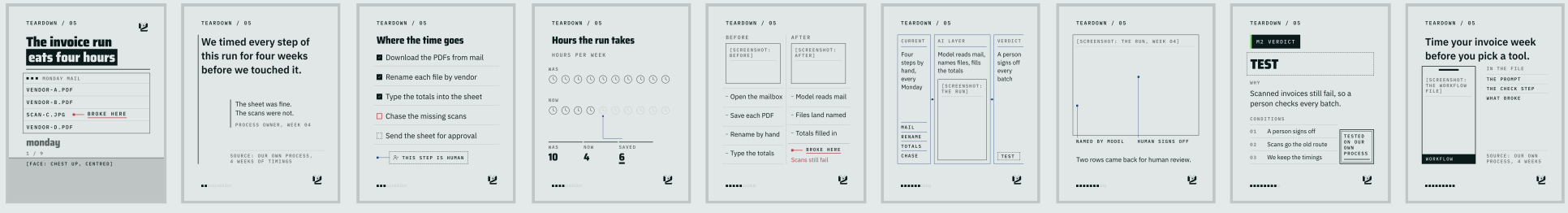
On from 0:38 to the end. Card is the 888 column on the 96 guide, bottom on y 1000, inside Zone A

All three ship as transparent 1080 by 1920 PNGs, laid over the footage in the editor and never rebuilt in it. Fix the position for the whole piece and swap only the text, at a beat boundary, with no transition.

# Templates: Carousel

A carousel is the format people save, so it has to hold up on a second reading. There are nine slide types and one shared chrome: the format tag top left, one square per slide bottom left, the mark bottom right. Real screenshots go into the frames marked [SCREENSHOT: ...], and the stickers carry the state and the numbers, so no slide is type on its own.

THE NINE SLIDES, 1080 BY 1350, AT 26 MM WIDE



01 cover

02 statement

03 list

04 isotype

05 before after

06 scheme

07 proof

08 verdict

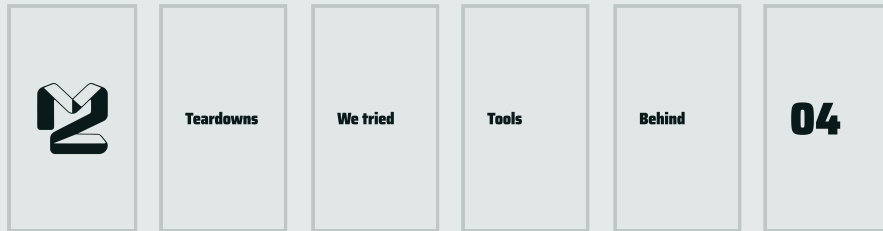
09 next

| SLIDE        | WHAT IT IS FOR                                          | STICKERS IT USES                          | SLOTS TAKING A SCREENSHOT |
|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| cover        | Stops the scroll and names the piece                    | 37 screen card, 44 face frame, 24 counter | none                      |
| statement    | The claim in one sentence, with the person it came from | 45 quote plate, 50 source plate           | none                      |
| list         | Where the time goes, three to five rows, one state each | 27 checklist rows, 15 human step plate    | none                      |
| isotype      | One quantity, counted in repeated units                 | 34 isotype row, 21 was now saved          | none                      |
| before_after | The same run twice, four rows a column, and what broke  | 20 broke-here marker                      | shot_before, shot_after   |
| scheme       | The workflow as boxes, and where the model sits         | 28 step chain, 18 verdict chip            | shot_run                  |
| proof        | The capture that backs the claim, with two callouts     | 13 callout up, drawn twice                | shot_proof                |
| verdict      | The call, the reason and the conditions it holds under  | 05 verdict header, 18 chip, 19 stamp      | none                      |
| next         | What to do with this, and where the file to copy lives  | 36 phone frame, 50 source plate           | shot_next                 |

# Templates: Profile

Highlight cover 1080x1920, avatar 1080x1080, mark 620 px, circle inset 54 px. Both are cropped to a circle by Instagram, so nothing here is meant to be read at the smallest displayed size.

## HIGHLIGHT COVER, SIX FILLED EXAMPLES



1-start-here: mark  
2-teardowns: word  
3-we-tried: word  
4-tools: word  
5-behind: word  
6-numeral: numeral

## CIRCLE CROP AREA, THE MIDDLE 1080X1080 BAND



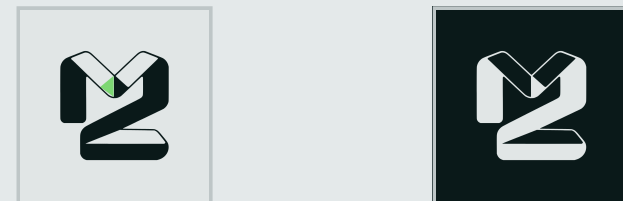
Circle crop area

Circle crop area

Full 9:16 frame

Full 9:16 frame

## AVATAR, TWO SURFACES



paper-color: the colour mark on Paper. The avatar the account ships with

ink-mono-paper: the mono Paper mark on Ink. The only other avatar in the system

Avatar supersedes [source/avatar-final-2026-09-01.png](#). Render **paper-color** and upload it as the profile picture.

# Tokens reference

Every value in the system, generated from `tokens/tokens.json` into `tokens/out/tokens.flat.json`. Nothing outside this list is a value the system has.

| COLOR.BASE              |         | SIZE              | SAFE    |                                         | CANVAS, W X H       |                 | LOGO         |                       |                   |         |
|-------------------------|---------|-------------------|---------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------|-----------------|--------------|-----------------------|-------------------|---------|
| paper                   | #E4E9EA | hook.min          | 90px    | reel.top                                | 269px               | reel            | 1080x1920    | min-width-color       | 32px              |         |
| ink                     | #0C1D1D | hook.default      | 96px    | reel.bottom                             | 672px               | story           | 1080x1920    | min-width-mono        | 20px              |         |
| signal                  | #7DD774 | hook.max          | 104px   | reel.side                               | 65px                | feed-portrait   | 1080x1350    | clearspace            | 0.25              |         |
| oxide                   | #BB4347 | hook.fallback-4x5 | 84px    | reel.organic-bottom                     | 450px               | feed-tall       | 1080x1440    | size-reel             | 120px             |         |
| blueprint               | #1E4A80 | title.default     | 72px    | reel.right-rail                         | 130px               | feed-square     | 1080x1080    | size-feed             | 96px              |         |
| graphite                | #5C6565 | body.lead         | 52px    | reel.grid-crop-top                      | 240px               | carousel        | 1080x1350    | size-avatar           | 620px             |         |
| rule                    | #BEC6C7 | body.default      | 46px    | reel.grid-crop-bottom                   | 260px               | avatar          | 1080x1080    |                       |                   |         |
|                         |         | body.small        | 42px    | reel.right-rail-top                     | 1000px              | highlight       | 1080x1920    | MOTION                |                   |         |
| COLOR, SEMANTIC ALIASES |         | caption.default   | 40px    | feed-square.grid-crop-side              | 135px               |                 |              | duration.instant      | 0ms               |         |
| surface.primary         | #E4E9EA | label.default     | 36px    | feed-portrait.grid-crop-side            | 34px                | FRAME           |              | duration.quick        | 120ms             |         |
| surface.dark            | #0C1D1D | label.small       | 32px    | circle-inset                            | 54px                | pad-x           | 96px         | duration.standard     | 200ms             |         |
| surface.plate           | #0C1D1D |                   |         |                                         |                     | pad-top-reel    | 272px        | duration.hold         | 400ms             |         |
| text.on-light           | #0C1D1D | LEADING           |         | FONT.FAMILY                             |                     | pad-bottom-reel | 672px        | duration.isotype-step | 80ms              |         |
| text.on-dark            | #E4E9EA | hook              | 1.03    | display                                 | Saira SemiCondensed | pad-y-feed      | 96px         | duration.verdict-min  | 3000ms            |         |
| text.secondary          | #5C6565 | body              | 1.35    | text                                    | IBM Plex Sans       | gutter          | 24px         | onscreen              |                   |         |
| text.secondary-on-dark  | #BEC6C7 | caption           | 1.2     | mono                                    | IBM Plex Mono       | indent          | 24px         | easing.default        | 0,0,1,1           |         |
| accent.data             | #7DD774 | label             | 1       | Fallbacks, in order: IBM Plex Sans      |                     |                 | columns      | 4                     |                   |         |
| accent.alert            | #BB4347 |                   |         | Condensed, Arial Narrow, sans-serif for |                     |                 | column-width | 204px                 | VERDICT           |         |
| accent.structure        | #1E4A80 | TRACKING          |         | display; Helvetica Neue, Arial, sans-   |                     |                 |              |                       | keep.fill         | #0C1D1D |
| line.on-light           | #BEC6C7 | hook              | -0.01em | serif for text; ui-monospace, Menlo,    |                     |                 | SPACE        |                       | keep.fill-on-dark | #7DD774 |
| line.on-dark            | #BEC6C7 | body              | 0em     | monospace for mono.                     |                     |                 | 1            | 8px                   | keep.stroke       | none    |
| line.diagram            | #1E4A80 | caption           | 0em     |                                         |                     | 2               | 16px         | keep.style            | solid             |         |
| line.on-dark-muted      | #5C6565 | label             | 0.16em  |                                         |                     | 3               | 24px         | kill.fill             | transparent       |         |
|                         |         |                   |         | FONT.WEIGHT                             |                     | 4               | 32px         | kill.stroke           | #BB4347           |         |
| CHIP                    |         | MEASURE           |         | regular                                 | 400                 | 6               | 48px         | kill.stroke-width     | 4px               |         |
| width                   | 160px   | hook-chars        | 20      | medium                                  | 500                 | 8               | 64px         | kill.style            | solid             |         |
| height                  | 56px    | body-chars        | 38      | semibold                                | 600                 | 12              | 96px         | test.fill             | transparent       |         |
| pad-x                   | 24px    | hook-words-reel   | 8       | bold                                    | 700                 | 16              | 128px        | test.stroke           | #0C1D1D           |         |
| gap                     | 16px    | hook-words-4x5    | 6       | extrabold                               | 800                 |                 |              | test.stroke-width     | 2px               |         |
|                         |         |                   |         | display                                 | 900                 | STROKE          |              | test.style            | dashed            |         |
| BANNED                  |         |                   |         |                                         |                     | hairline        | 2px          |                       |                   |         |
| radius                  | 0px     |                   |         |                                         |                     | emphasis        | 4px          |                       |                   |         |
| shadow                  | none    |                   |         |                                         |                     | dash            | 12px 8px     |                       |                   |         |
| gradient                | none    |                   |         |                                         |                     |                 |              |                       |                   |         |
| text-align-center       | never   |                   |         |                                         |                     |                 |              |                       |                   |         |

# Gates for agents

The router decides which one file an agent loads. The linter decides what ships.

THE FIVE ACTIVE RULES

- Colours, sizes, spacing and fonts are token values. Nothing is picked to look similar.
- Paper is the primary surface. Ink is for Reel covers and plates on video. Oxide means broken, Signal means lit data on dark, or the mark.
- Everything is left-aligned on the 4-column grid with a 24 px indent. Hierarchy by size and weight.
- Hook, mark, verdict and format tag sit inside Zone A of the placement. Subtitles may use Zone B. Nothing in Zone C.
- Verdicts are shape-coded: KEEP filled, KILL 4 px outline, TEST dashed. Numbers are never naked: WAS, NOW or SAVED.

THE ROUTER, FROM SKILL.MD

| TASK                  | LOAD                                 |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Writing a caption     | brand/04-voice.md, 05-vocabulary.md  |
| Checking a claim      | brand/01-positioning.md              |
| Planning a Reel       | brand/06-formats.md                  |
| Pairing colours       | rules/color.md                       |
| Setting type          | rules/typography.md                  |
| Placing elements      | rules/layout.md, social/instagram.md |
| Icons and chips       | rules/iconography.md                 |
| Shooting and screens  | rules/imagery.md                     |
| Captions and timing   | rules/motion.md                      |
| Using the mark        | brand/logo/README.md                 |
| Judging a visual idea | composition/rules.md, not-this.md    |

BEFORE ANYTHING IS PUBLISHED

- Can the topic and the verdict be understood with the sound off?
- Is it recognisable as M2 with the handle hidden?
- Is the proof ours?
- Is a human review step named?
- Does the closing line give an action the viewer can take alone?

MECHANICAL CHECKS

```
node checks/lint.mjs templates/<name>/
node checks/contrast.mjs
node social/overlays/check-overlay.mjs
<placement>
```

SAMPLING RULE FOR BATCHES

Over 10 assets in one batch, inspect every k-th file, k as the batch size over 10 rounded down, minimum 1, chosen before rendering rather than after seeing results, plus every asset whose hook hit the 20-character cap.

# The linter

Twenty-one rules, in `checks/lint-rules.json`, run by `node checks/lint.mjs <path>`. Every rule is an error except **filled-duotone-icon**, which warns. Fifteen of them are the machine form of a Not This item; the other six enforce our own values.

## cream-terracotta

Warm cream background with a terracotta or clay accent, within RGB distance 40 of the named AI-default pair.

## near-black-acid-accent

A hex within distance 40 of the acid-green or vermilion default accent that is not a palette colour.

## fake-black

A tinted near-black standing in for true black.

## purple-gradient-hero

A purple or indigo gradient used as a hero background.

## any-gradient

Any linear or radial gradient used as decoration.

## uniform-radius

A border-radius other than 0.

## soft-card-shadow

A box-shadow other than none.

## default-sans-fonts

Inter, Roboto, Open Sans, Lato, Geist, Space Grotesk or Instrument Serif instead of IBM Plex.

## emoji-as-icon

An emoji code point where an icon or a copy character is required.

## emdash-label

A label built as a word, a spaced em dash, then a fragment.

## arrow-cta

An arrow glyph appended to link or button text.

## color-outside-tokens

A hex literal not present in `tokens.json` `color.base`.

## font-outside-plex

A family outside IBM Plex Sans, Sans Condensed and Mono and the `tokens.json` fallbacks.

## centered-text

`text-align center`, or an SVG `text-anchor` set to middle.

## filled-duotone-icon

Warn only. An SVG path fill other than none or `currentColor` inside templates or assets.

## drop-shadow-filter

A filter drop-shadow on any element.

## banned-vocabulary

Copy matching a phrase from the do-not-publish list in `brand/05-vocabulary.md`.

## long-dash-copy

A long dash in copy. Use a comma or a full stop.

## hook-words-limit

A hook over 8 words, or over 6 when the filename carries 4x5 or carousel.

## hook-line-chars

A hook line over `measure.hook-chars`, 20.

## body-line-chars

A body line over `measure.body-chars`, 38.

### WHAT IT READS

Code rules run on html, css and svg. Copy rules, the vocabulary and long-dash checks, run on md, txt and json with `--copy`. Slot rules run on any json file carrying a `slots` object, and take the word and character limits from `tokens.json`.

### WHERE THE VALUES COME FROM

The palette comes from `tokens.json` `color.base`, the allowed families from `font.family`, the line caps from `measure`, and the banned phrase list from `brand/05-vocabulary.md`. Changing a value changes the linter with it.

### FIXTURES

Four fixtures in `checks/fixtures/` prove the linter still catches what it claims to catch: `good.html`, `bad.html`, `bad-copy.md` and `bad-4x5.json`. Run them before trusting a clean report on real work.

# Not this

Two lists. Part A is what generative models fall into by default, from Anthropic's published clusters and a 46,971-post corpus. Part B is what would break our own system. The third line of each entry is the rule that checks it.

## PART A, DEFAULTS OF GENERATIVE MODELS

**Cream ground with a terracotta accent**

The most common AI-design cluster  
cream-terracotta

**Near-black with one acid or vermilion accent**

The second named default cluster  
near-black-acid-accent

**Tinted near-black standing in for true black**

Template chrome, whatever the subject  
fake-black

**Purple or indigo gradient hero**

Second most-cited complaint in the corpus  
purple-gradient-hero

**Any gradient wash as background**

The SaaS-card kit cluster, not one of ours  
any-gradient

**Uniform rounded corners on every card**

One radius regardless of hierarchy  
uniform-radius

**Identical soft grey drop shadow**

Same SaaS-card cluster  
soft-card-shadow

**Default sans fonts, Inter and its family**

Named in the 1590-landing-page study  
default-sans-fonts

## PART A, CONTINUED

**Emoji standing in for icons**

0.5 per cent of profile posts in the corpus  
emoji-as-icon

**Tracked-out caps eyebrow over every heading**

Named as a generated-page tell  
allcaps-eyebrow, not-this only

**Meta strings joined with middle dots**

Template chrome  
middot-metastring, not-this only

**One headline word in italic or a second colour**

One of the commonest tells  
judgment call

**An arrow glyph on link or button text**

Template chrome  
arrow-cta

**Fade and slide up on every section**

The named generic motion default  
judgment call

**Numbered markers on content that is not a sequence**

Named, and not machine-checkable  
judgment call

## PART B, DEVIATIONS FROM OUR OWN SYSTEM

**Colour outside the token palette**

tokens.json is the only source of a value  
color-outside-tokens

**Font outside the IBM Plex family**

Plex Sans, Sans Condensed, Mono  
font-outside-plex

**Size or spacing outside the scale**

Eight steps, and nothing between them  
judgment call

**Centred text of any kind**

Swiss grid source, item three  
centered-text

**A number without WAS, NOW or SAVED**

Oscilloscope source, item four  
judgment call

**Filled or duotone icons**

Outline only  
filled-duotone-icon

**The logo on a busy photograph**

It stops being a mark and becomes texture  
judgment call

**A primary element outside Zone A**

Zone A is x 65 to 1015, y 269 to 1248  
check-overlay.mjs

# Colophon

---

## TYPEFACES

Saira SemiCondensed Black for display, IBM Plex Sans for text, IBM Plex Mono Medium for labels and figures. IBM Plex Sans Condensed remains only as the fallback inside the display stack. No other family is used anywhere in the system.

---

## LICENCE

IBM Plex and Saira are released under the SIL Open Font License 1.1. The licence texts ship with the repository at `assets/fonts/LICENSE-OFL.txt` and `assets/fonts/LICENSE-OFL-Saira.txt`. The fonts are embedded in this PDF as permitted by that licence.

---

## COLOUR

Seven values, all defined in `tokens/tokens.json`. No colour appears in this document that is not one of them.

---

## SOURCE OF TRUTH

`tokens/tokens.json` holds every value. The print stylesheet mirrors it at `pdf/print.css`; when `tokens/out/tokens.css` is generated, the stylesheet imports it instead.

---

## HOW TO REBUILD

From the repository root, run `node pdf/build.mjs`. The script assembles `pdf/out/document.html` from `pdf/shell.html` plus every file in `pdf/sections/brand/` and `pdf/sections/system/` in filename order, then prints it with headless Chrome to `pdf/out/M2-Lab-Brandbook.pdf`. Use `node pdf/build.mjs --html-only` to assemble without printing.

---

## PAGE FORMAT

A4 landscape, 297 by 210 mm, 16 mm margins, text indented a further 24 px off the guide.